

The **United States of America (USA)**, also known as the **United States (U.S.)** or **America**, is a country primarily located in [North America](#). It is a [federal republic](#) consisting of 50 [states](#) and a [federal capital district](#), [Washington, D.C.](#) The 48 [contiguous states](#) border [Canada](#) to the north and [Mexico](#) to the south, with the [semi-exclave](#) of [Alaska](#) in the northwest and the [archipelago](#) of [Hawaii](#) in the [Pacific Ocean](#). The United States also asserts sovereignty over five [major island territories](#) and various [uninhabited islands](#) in [Oceania](#) and the [Caribbean](#).^[i] It is a [megadiverse country](#), with the world's [third-largest land area](#)^[c] and [third-largest population](#), exceeding 341 million.^[j]

[Paleo-Indians](#) first migrated from North Asia to North America at least 15,000 years ago, and formed various civilizations. [European discovery of the Americas](#) began in 1492, and [British colonization](#) followed with the 1607 settlement of [Virginia](#), the first of the [Thirteen Colonies](#). The [American Enlightenment](#) that spread throughout the colonies in the 18th century valued [republicanism](#) and [liberalism](#). Clashes with the [British Crown](#) over [taxation without parliamentary representation](#) and the denial of other [English rights](#) evolved into the [American Revolution](#), which led to the July 2, 1776, [Lee Resolution](#) formally declaring independence from Great Britain. Two days later, on the [Fourth of July](#), the [Declaration of Independence](#) was adopted and publicly released. Victory in the 1775–1783 [Revolutionary War](#) brought [international recognition of the country's sovereignty](#).

The U.S. rapidly [expanded its territory westward](#) by purchasing, settling and conquering various areas controlled by Europeans and Indigenous peoples. As more states were [admitted into the Union](#), a North–South [division over slavery](#) led 11 Southern states to [declare secession](#) and join as the [Confederate States of America](#) in order to [preserve slavery there](#). These states fought against the [Union](#) in the [American Civil War](#) of 1861–1865 and were defeated. With the United States' victory and reunification, slavery was [abolished nationally](#).